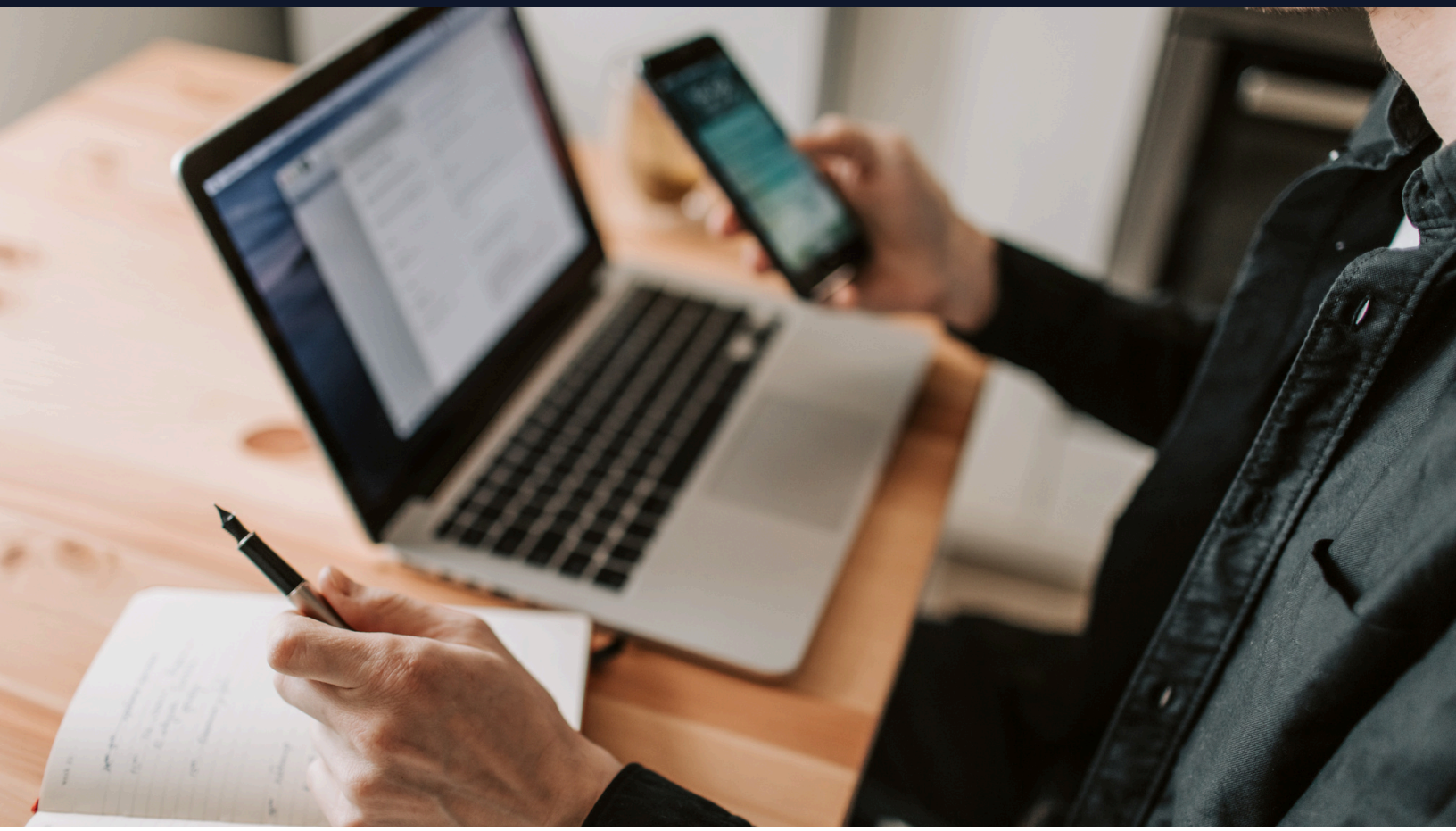
14 Most Common Mistakes Businesses Make

AND HOW TO FIX THEM



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INTRODUCTION

BUSINESS MISTAKES

Most teams don't struggle because they lack effort or talent. They struggle because the information they need is scattered across too many tools

This guide outlines commoon operational problems that quietly slow teams down - the kind that don't show up as obvious failures, but as delays, confusion, and unnecessary rework.

As you read, notice which examples feel familiar. They're often early signals that your systems are working against you, not for you.

We believe good systems should make work feel simpler, not heavier. This guide is intended to help teams step back, identify friction, and move toward more connected ways of working.

-ETA Digital

MISTAKE #1

Tool Soup

WHEN WORK IS SPREAD ACROSS TOO MANY SYSTEMS

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Multiple tabs open at all times

All data for a project split between multiple tools

Jumping between multiple systems to complete a task

Over time, this complexity becomes normal – even though it isn't efficient

THE PROBLEM

Slower Progress – Tasks take longer than expected, making delivery feel unclear

Errors & Rework – Conflicting or outdated information creates mistakes

Hidden time tax – Constant context switching drains focus

Duplicate effort – The same information is entered in multiple places

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ "Where is that?" gets asked daily
- ✓ Onboarding requires verbal walkthroughs
- ✓ Staff keep personal tracking sheets

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – Time spent switching tools makes progress invisible

Blind Spot Ops – Managers lack real-time visibility

Ad-hoc Reporting – Updates require manual digging

MISTAKE #2

Spreadsheet Glue

WHEN SPREADSHEETS BECOME YOUR CORE SYSTEMS

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Core operations (orders, projects, inventory, reporting) live in spreadsheets

A few key people understand how the sheets actually work

Tabs, columns, and formulas keep getting added over time

Net result: your "system" isn't designed to support normal business growth, and your team spends more time maintaining the spreadsheet and hunting for info than moving work forward.

THE PROBLEM

Slow & Fragile – Large sheets are clunky, error-prone, and hard to maintain

Manual Rework – Any process change means new columns, tabs, or logic

Workarounds Multiply – People export, copy, or create side sheets to cope

Version Confusion – Multiple copies exist, with no single source of truth

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ Teams jump between multiple spreadsheets to find information

✓ Sheets keep growing in size, number, and complexity

✓ New starters need to be "trained on the spreadsheet" like it's core software

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Hidden errors creep into day-to-day operations

Reporting takes longer and feels unreliable

The system struggles as volume and complexity increase

MISTAKE #3

Key-Person Ops

WHEN THE BUSINESS RUNS ON A FEW "INDISPENSABLE" PEOPLE

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

One or two people everyone goes to for "quick questions"

They understand the real processes, spreadsheets, and workarounds

Exceptions, complaints, and edge cases always go through them

When they're busy, off sick, or on holiday, work slows down — or stops entirely.

THE PROBLEM

Knowledge Concentration – How things actually work lives in people's heads, not systems

Constant Firefighting – Key people get pulled into approvals, checks, and fixes all day

Bottlenecks Form – Work stacks up around their availability

Scaling Breaks – Hiring more people doesn't help if knowledge isn't shared

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ You can name the 1–3 people the business couldn't function without

✓ When they're away, everyone hopes nothing big goes wrong

✓ Decisions often pause with "I'll need to check with X"

✓ New staff default to messaging the same person when stuck

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – A constant stream of untracked questions and edge cases

Manual Coordination – Managers spend time unblocking instead of improving systems

Version Confusion – People trust individuals over documentation

Firefighting Culture – Processes can't be improved because they're not written down

MISTAKE #4

Onboarding Drag

WHEN NEW HIRES CAN'T FOLLOW A CLEAR SYSTEM

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

New starters learn by shadowing and asking questions, not following a system

SOPs exist but are out of date or don't match reality

People keep personal notes, screenshots, or mini-spreadsheets to cope

It takes weeks or months before new hires can work independently

Net result: you pay twice for every new hire — once in salary, and again in the hidden time spent training, checking, and fixing work far longer than necessary.

THE PROBLEM

High Training Load – Your best people repeat the same explanations over and over

Slow Scaling – Every new hire requires heavy manual onboarding

Inconsistent Execution – People do the same tasks in slightly different ways

Low Confidence – New hires hesitate and ask constant small questions

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ Trainers say "ignore that bit, we do it differently now"
- ✓ New hires keep asking about tasks they were already trained on
- ✓ Hiring feels risky because onboarding slows the team down
- ✓ The onboarding plan is basically "sit with X and watch"

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Key-Person Ops – Verbal training deepens reliance on a few experienced people

Ghost Work – Managers drown in repeat "how do I...?" questions

Policy in Docs, Not Systems – Written rules aren't enforced by tools

Version Confusion – No one knows which process is the current one

MISTAKE #5

Manual Coordination

WHEN WORK ONLY MOVES AFTER SOMEONE CHASES IT

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Managers spend the day sending "Where is this up to?" messages

There's no clear view of what's blocked, who owns it, or what's next

Work sits idle until someone realises and nudges the next person

Net result: your most valuable people do the most admin — pushing work forward by force instead of designing a system where work flows on its own.

THE PROBLEM

Low-Value Manager Time – Chasing replaces decision-making and improvement

Fragile Flow – When managers are busy or away, work stalls

Passive Behaviour – Staff wait for prompts instead of taking ownership

Hidden Bottlenecks – It's hard to see where work actually gets stuck

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ You end the day feeling like you've mostly chased people

✓ Chats and inboxes are full of follow-ups and reminders

✓ Clients only get updates after they chase — and you chase internally

✓ When managers are away, everything noticeably slows down

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – Constant check-ins create invisible, untracked effort

Firefighting Culture – No time to fix root causes, so problems repeat

Tool Soup – Status updates require digging through multiple systems

Blind Spot Ops – Leaders lack visibility into real bottleneck

MISTAKE #6

Ad Hoc Reporting

WHEN CLIENT UPDATES ARE MANUAL AND PAINFUL

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Client updates require digging through multiple tools and spreadsheets

Managers have to ask around to find out where work is up to

Every report feels like a one-off, time-sucking task

Net result: you burn payroll rebuilding reports your systems should generate in seconds — just to show clients and leaders what's going on.

THE PROBLEM

Reporting as Extra Work – Updates sit on top of real work, not inside it

Manual Clean-Up – Data must be reformatted, checked, and stitched together

Instantly Outdated – Reports go stale as soon as they're sent

Expensive Time – Senior staff burn hours producing updates instead of leading

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ Teams lose hours each month preparing reports and chasing updates

✓ Clients go long stretches without updates because they're hard to produce

✓ If manual updates stopped, visibility would drop fast

✓ Meetings trigger last-minute scrambles to "pull the numbers together"

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – Bespoke updates add invisible, untracked workload

Manual Coordination – Managers chase people just to get information

Blind Spot Ops – Without reports, no one can see what's really happening

Firefighting Culture – Updates are rushed, late, and error-prone

MISTAKE #7

Approval Maze

WHEN WORK STALLS WAITING FOR THE GREEN LIGHT

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Tasks and projects regularly sit at "waiting for approval"

Approvals live in inboxes, DMs, or chat threads — not in a workflow

People send follow-ups like "Just bumping this" or "Can you confirm?"

Staff push more decisions up than necessary to avoid blame

Net result: progress is controlled by inboxes and availability, turning approvals into a bottleneck that quietly slows the entire business.

THE PROBLEM

Senior Time Drain – Leaders spend hours approving small decisions

Stop-Start Flow – Work moves in bursts when approvals get cleared

Missed Work – Requests get buried, forgotten, or rediscovered late

Low Ownership – Teams wait for sign-off instead of acting

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ "We're just waiting for X to approve it" is a common blocker
- ✓ Managers feel stuck in approvals all day just to keep work moving
- ✓ Important items resurface days later with "Sorry, missed this"
- ✓ People ask for approval on things they should own themselves

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – Chasing approvals creates invisible admin for everyone

Manual Coordination – Decisions rely on nudging, not workflows

Blind Spot Ops – Everything looks stuck, hiding real bottlenecks

Key-Person Ops – Progress depends on a few people staying available

MISTAKE #8

Blind Spot Ops

WHEN YOU CAN'T SEE WHERE WORK IS REALLY UP TO

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Managers have to ask people for updates instead of checking a system

Problems surface late, usually when a deadline or client is already at risk

Different people give different answers about the same project or order

Net result: you're forced into reactive management — constantly responding to surprises instead of proactively steering the business.

THE PROBLEM

Low Visibility – Leaders can't see progress without interrupting the team

Update Overhead – Time is spent preparing status updates instead of doing work

Poor Planning – Capacity, hiring, and deadlines are hard to judge confidently

Hidden Bottlenecks – Small issues build quietly until they become urgent

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ You often ask "What's the latest on X?"

✓ There's no central place to see project or order status

✓ You suspect workload is uneven but can't see it clearly

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Manual Coordination – Managers chase updates instead of reading them

Ghost Work – Time is wasted gathering information that should be visible

Firefighting Culture – Issues only surface when they're already urgent

Ad Hoc Reporting – Status must be manually stitched together for updates

MISTAKE #9

Undefined Ownership

WHEN NO ONE IS AUTOMATICALLY TOLD TO TAKE THE NEXT STEP

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

You only discover missed work when a client chases or a deadline is close

Delays trigger "I thought X was doing that" conversations

Tasks are owned by "the team" or "the department", not a person

Work floats between inboxes, chats, and spreadsheets with no clear owner

Covering for someone is hard because it's unclear what they actually own

Net result: important work falls through the cracks, deadlines slip, and managers spend their time untangling ownership instead of improving the system.

THE PROBLEM

Manager Intervention – Leaders have to step in just to assign and reassign work

Work in Limbo – Tasks aren't actively worked on, but aren't clearly blocked either

Loud Beats Important – People focus on emails and complaints, not priorities

Blame Avoidance – Fuzzy ownership encourages "not my job" behaviour

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

✓ You regularly reassign or chase tasks everyone assumed were handled

✓ You hear "I didn't realise that was mine" all the time

✓ Overdue work starts with figuring out who owns it

✓ Tasks are assigned to groups or shared inboxes, not individuals

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Manual Coordination – Managers chase and reassign work to keep things moving

Blind Spot Ops – It's hard to see what's stuck without clear ownership

Ghost Work – Time is wasted just working out who should do what

Firefighting Culture – Unclear ownership prevents clean, repeatable workflows

MISTAKE #10

Ghost Work

WHEN INVISIBLE BUSYWORK DRAINS TEAM CAPACITY

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Simple tasks take longer than they should

People feel busy all day but struggle to show real progress

Time is spent hunting for information before work can even start

"Quick questions" constantly interrupt focus

Net result: payroll rises, stress increases, and visible output lags — you're paying a hidden ghost work tax every day.

THE PROBLEM

Invisible Load – Chasing info, clarifying details, and switching tools eats time

Misleading Capacity – From the outside, it looks like the team should do more

False Hiring Pressure – Leaders assume they need more people

Burnout Risk – Effort feels high, progress feels low

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ You keep hiring, but output doesn't improve as expected
- ✓ "I was just dealing with stuff all day" is a common answer
- ✓ Delays are explained by waiting, searching, or clarifying
- ✓ Interruptions are constant and unavoidable

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Firefighting Culture – No time left to improve systems

Key-Person Ops – Teams rely on a few people who "know everything"

Tool Soup + Spreadsheet Glue – Work requires stitching info together

MISTAKE #11

Version Confusion

WHEN NO ONE KNOWS WHICH PROCESS IS THE RIGHT ONE

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

People ask colleagues instead of checking a system

Multiple SOPs or checklists exist for the same process

No one is sure whether a document is current or outdated

Documentation exists, but it isn't trusted.

Net result: instead of one clear way of working, you get a messy mix of memory, guesswork, and conflicting documents that slows execution and makes scaling harder.

THE PROBLEM

Senior Interruptions – Experienced staff get flooded with "how do we do this?"

Broken Onboarding – New hires can't simply "follow the docs"

Low Trust – People rely on memory, not documentation

Inconsistent Execution – Different versions of the same process are followed

Change Resistance – No single, agreed version to improve or automate

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ You find multiple docs describing the same process
- ✓ People give different answers to "what's the current process?"
- ✓ You hear "Which version are we using now?" regularly
- ✓ SOPs describe steps that aren't actually followed

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Key-Person Ops – Teams rely on a few people who "know the real way"

Change Shock – Updating processes means chasing multiple versions

Ghost Work – Time is wasted hunting for or double-checking docs

Policy in Docs, Not Systems – Written rules drift from real execution

MISTAKE #12

Policy in Docs, Not in Systems

WHEN PROCESSES ARE WRITTEN DOWN BUT NOT ENFORCED

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

SOPs live in documents, while work happens in other tools

Critical steps rely on memory instead of system enforcement

The "official" process exists — but the system doesn't support it.

Net result: processes look solid on paper, but day-to-day execution drifts — leading to inconsistency, missed steps, and repeat problems.

THE PROBLEM

Skipped Steps – Busy staff bypass parts of the process

Process Drift – Written SOPs fall out of sync with reality

Weak Leverage – Updating docs doesn't change behaviour

Low Reliability – Tools don't nudge or enforce the right actions

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ Updating SOPs doesn't change day-to-day behaviour
- ✓ Processes are enforced by documents, not workflows
- ✓ People say "I forgot that step" during reviews
- ✓ Shortcuts quietly become the norm

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work + Key-Person Ops – Managers clarify what to do

Blind Spot Ops – Hard to see if processes are followed

Version Confusion – Docs lose credibility over time

Change Shock – Every process update needs reminders and retraining

MISTAKE #13

Firefighting-First Culture

WHEN FIXING TODAY'S PROBLEMS LEAVES NO TIME TO FIX THE SYSTEM

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Most days are spent coping with issues in the current way of working
The real process lives in people's heads and scattered tools
Process improvement is always postponed because everyone is "too busy"
The business runs on constant reaction, not deliberate design.

Net result: you stay stuck fighting problems created by your own systems, while competitors with cleaner operations pull further ahead.

THE PROBLEM

Falling Behind – Competitors evolve while your processes stay static

People-Dependent Ops – Problems are solved by effort, not prevention

Symptom Fixing – Issues are patched instead of addressing root causes

Permanent Busyness – Improvement is always delayed to "later"

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ Most key SOPs aren't clearly mapped and system-enforced
- ✓ Leaders spend more time in the business than on it
- ✓ People say "I'd love to improve this, but we don't have time"
- ✓ Mapping a process reveals multiple versions and no agreement

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Ghost Work – Inefficiencies are never removed

Blind Spot Ops – Lack of visibility into real flow

Tool Soup + Spreadsheet Glue – Work stays scattered

Policy in Docs, Not Systems – Written processes drift from reality

MISTAKE #14

Change Shock

WHEN EVEN SMALL CHANGES ARE HARD TO IMPLEMENT

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

Changes are announced in emails and meetings, not enforced by systems

Weeks later, different people follow different versions of the process

Even small updates require changing multiple tools, sheets, and docs

Change creates disruption instead of improvement.

Net result: the business becomes hard to improve. Change feels risky, so outdated processes stay in place — even when everyone knows they're holding the company back.

THE PROBLEM

Change Resistance – People stick to old habits because change feels chaotic

Leadership Hesitation – Improvements are delayed to avoid disruption

High Update Cost – Updating the "real" process takes too much manual effort

Partial Rollouts – Not everything is updated at once, so inconsistency spreads

Lost Ideas – People stop suggesting improvements

SIGNS THIS IS YOU

- ✓ Sensible improvements are met with "changing this will be a nightmare"
- ✓ You hear "I didn't realise that had changed" long after rollout
- ✓ Multiple versions of the same process still exist
- ✓ Outdated processes linger far longer than they should

DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS

Policy in Docs, Not Systems – New processes aren't enforced

Firefighting Culture – Changes only happen once things break

Version Confusion – Old instructions never fully disappear

Onboarding Drag – New hires lack a single source of truth